

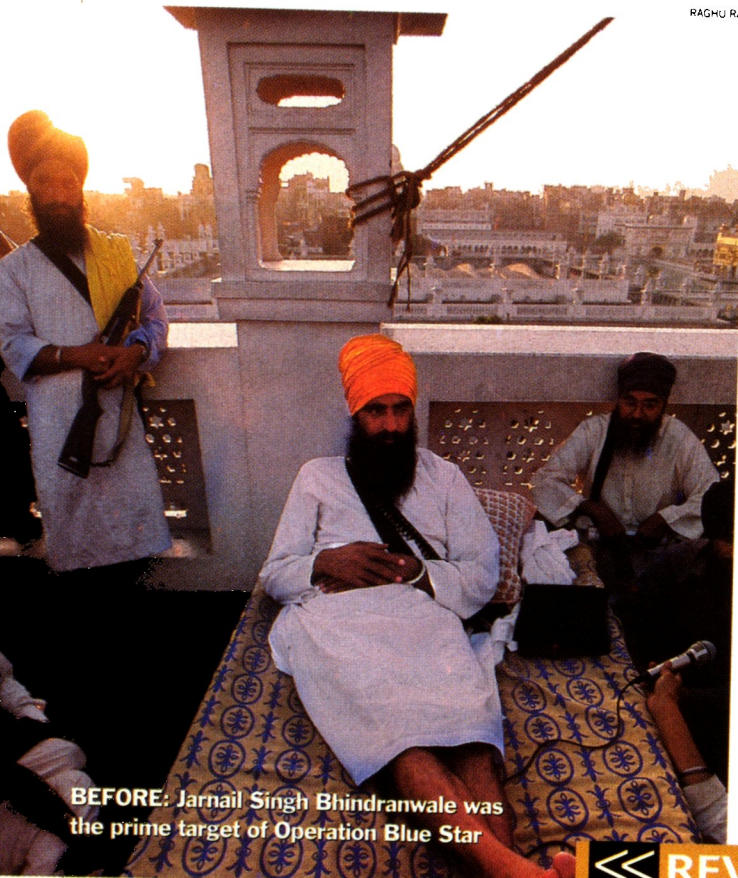
1984

PUNJAB BURNING

RAGHU RAI

AFTER: The Golden Temple after the military operation

RAGHU RAI



BEFORE: Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale was the prime target of Operation Blue Star

◀ REWIND

"Don't shed blood but shed hatred," Indira Gandhi said on AIR but the army was already preparing for assault. Operation Blue Star was Indira's medicine to cure Punjab of its militant fever. She had hoped the operation would be smooth, swift and effective. But when on June 5 tanks rolled into the Golden Temple, half the battle—the hearts and minds of the Punjabis—had been lost. The body counts only made it clearer. When Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale's body was extricated from the debris of the Akal Takht on June 6, many of his followers refused to believe he was dead. Prophet of hate to some, messiah to others, Bhindranwale led the first purge of Hindus from what he considered to be the state of Khalistan.

"Terrorism is encouraged most by weakness in political leadership and confusion in the security forces."

FIRST CUT

Squadron Leader Rakesh Sharma was launched into orbit aboard the Soyuz T-11 on April 2, to become the first

Indian in space. He famously said to Indira Gandhi's question about how India looked from up there, "*Saare jahaan se achcha*".

K.P.S. Gill

DGP Punjab on terrorism in the state in 1984.